SALES LESSON PLAN 03 / SOURCE MATERIAL

Understanding Customer Needs

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Level: B1

Duration: 60 minutes

Topic: Vocabulary for understanding customer needs

Main objective: By the end of the lesson, the student will be able to understand and use common vocabulary and expressions for identifying customer needs, problems, priorities, and requirements in a sales conversation.

1. Lead-in-Understanding the Customer

5-10 minutes

Start by getting the student to think about what salespeople need to know before offering a product or service.

The teacher asks:

What information do you need from a customer before selling them a product?

Why is it important to understand a customer's needs?

What questions can you ask a potential customer?

What problems might a customer have?

What is the difference between a need and a want?

What happens if a salesperson offers the wrong solution?

What information about a customer is important for a salesperson?

Quick brainstorm

Put these categories on the board:

CUSTOMER

> Needs
> Problems
> Goals
> Priorities
> Budget
> Requirements
> Preferences

Ask the student to give examples for each.

2. Warm-up activity-What Does the Customer Need?

5-10 minutes

Show the student three simple customer situations.

Customer A

"Our sales team is growing, but we're still using spreadsheets to manage our customers."

Ask:

What might this customer need?

Possible answers:

a CRM

better organization

automation

a system for managing customers

Customer B

"Our employees work from different locations, and it's difficult for them to communicate."

What might the customer need?

Customer C

"We have a limited budget, but we need to improve our customer service."

What might the customer need?

This introduces the distinction between what the customer says and what the salesperson needs to discover.

3. Vocabulary Presentation

15 minutes

The teacher organizes the vocabulary into four groups:

A. Customer Problems

Vocabulary

Meaning

problem

something that is causing difficulty

challenge

a difficult situation

issue

a problem or situation that needs attention

pain point

an important problem causing difficulty for the customer

difficulty

something that is difficult to do

concern

something that makes the customer worried

Examples

What is your biggest challenge at the moment?

What are your main pain points?

Do you have any concerns about the current system?

B. Customer Needs & Requirements

Vocabulary

Meaning

need

something necessary

requirement

something the customer specifically needs

priority

something more important than other things

expectation

what the customer expects

preference

something the customer likes more

solution

something that solves a problem

Examples

What are your main requirements?

What are your priorities?

What are your expectations?

What type of solution are you looking for?

C. Customer Goals

Vocabulary

Meaning

goal

something the customer wants to achieve

objective

a specific goal

improve

make something better

increase

make something bigger/higher

reduce

make something smaller/lower

achieve

successfully reach a goal

Examples

What are you hoping to achieve?

Are you looking to reduce costs?

Do you want to increase productivity?

What would you like to improve?

D. Understanding the Customer

Useful expressions:

What are you looking for?

What are your main priorities?

What challenges are you currently facing?

What are your main requirements?

Could you tell me more about that?

Could you give me an example?

What do you mean by...?

If I understand correctly...

So, your main concern is...

It sounds like you need...

Would it be important for you to...?

4. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

10 minutes

A. Match each word with its definition.

pain point

requirement

priority

concern

goal

preference

solution

expectation

challenge

objective

a. ___ something the customer expects to happen
b. ___ something the customer specifically needs
c. ___ something that solves a problem
d. ___ something that is especially important
e. ___ a difficult situation or problem
f. ___ something the customer wants to achieve
g. ___ something the customer likes more than another option
h. ___ something that makes a customer worried
i. ___ a specific aim or goal
j. ___ a problem that causes difficulty for a customer

B. Complete the sentences

Use:

requirements - priorities - pain points - goals - concerns - solution

What are your main _____ for this project?

Could you tell me about your biggest _____?

What are you hoping to achieve? What are your main _____?

What are your main _____ for the new system?

Do you have any _____ about changing providers?

Let's see if we can find the right _____ for your business.

5. Reading - A Sales Discovery Conversation

15 minutes

Understanding the Customer

Emma is a Sales Executive at TechSolutions, a company that provides software for small and medium-sized businesses. She is having a discovery call with David, the Operations Manager of a logistics company.

Emma: Thanks for taking the time to speak with me today. Before I tell you about our solutions, I'd like to understand your business and your current situation.

David: Sure. We're looking for a better way to manage our customer information.

Emma: I see. Could you tell me a little more about the problem?

David: At the moment, our information is in different spreadsheets. It's difficult for our sales and customer service teams to find the information they need.

Emma: So, one of your main challenges is having all your customer information in one place?

David: Exactly.

Emma: What are your main priorities at the moment?

David: We want to save time and improve communication between our teams.

Emma: And what would you like to improve specifically?

David: We'd like to respond to customers more quickly. At the moment, it can take two or three days to answer some requests.

Emma: I understand. What are your requirements for a new system?

David: It needs to be easy to use. We also need our sales and customer service teams to be able to access the same information.

Emma: That's helpful. Do you have any concerns about changing to a new system?

David: Yes. We're concerned about the cost and the time needed to train our employees.

Emma: That's understandable. So, if I understand correctly, your main priorities are improving communication, responding to customers more quickly, and saving time. At the same time, the solution needs to be easy to use and fit your budget.

David: Yes, that's exactly what we're looking for.

Emma: Great. Based on what you've told me, I think we may have a solution that could meet your needs. I'd like to show you how it works in our next meeting.

6. Reading Comprehension

A. Answer the questions.

What does David's company need?

Where is their customer information currently stored?

What is one of their main challenges?

What are two of their priorities?

What does David want to improve?

What are two requirements for the new system?

What are David's concerns?

What does Emma do before presenting a solution?

What does Emma summarize at the end of the conversation?

What does Emma suggest doing next?

7. Speaking - Customer Discovery Role-play

10-15 minutes

This should be the main production activity.

Situation

The student is a Sales Representative for a software company.

You are a potential customer.

Your company is having problems with its current customer-management system.

The student needs to discover your needs before recommending a solution.

The student must find out:

What problem you have

Your main challenges

Your priorities

Your goals

Your requirements

Your concerns

Your budget/preferences

7. Wrap-up & Feedback

5 minutes

The teacher gives feedback on:

Grammar accuracy

Vocabulary

Pronunciation

Fluency

Professional register

Visual resources from the original lesson plan


Smarter Solutions for Your Business
Our platform helps you work faster, collaborate better and grow.
Cloud-Based
Access from anywhere
Collaboration
Work together in real time
Secure
Your data, our priority
Scalable
Built for your growth
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